

A 90s story: Julian Weber pipped Neeraj Chopra with his last throw of the competition. AFP



and it's clear that it may take another 90m-plus throw to decide the winner of the 2025 World Championships in Japan this September, where Neeraj will be defending his title.

Now that Neeraj has breached the 90m mark, he's unlikely to want to just dip his foot into this elite range and step back out.

Injury-free, improved technique

If 2025 is when he is finally throwing pain-free, it's not just because he has recovered from the groin injury that plagued him since 2018. Another significant factor is his new coach — world record holder Jan Zelezny. While Neeraj only has good things to say about his previous coach Klaus — under whom he became Olympic and World Champion — it's clear Zelezny has bigger ambitions, driven by his unquestionable belief in Neeraj.

"Normally, he does not go to the Diamond Leagues, but he came with me because he told me that today is the day to achieve 90m," Neeraj said after the competition.

Under Zelezny, he has made small but significant corrections to his throwing technique. In the past, Neeraj had observed that his throws often drifted to the left of the field rather than flying straight, costing him crucial metres.

Now, Neeraj's left leg comes down to make the block a lot faster than before. The block is the step where the thrower plants his left foot, forcing the body to pivot, and transferring forward momentum into the javelin's propulsion.

This latest adjustment prevents Neeraj from falling over to one side as much as he used to. He's also holding the javelin more parallel to the runway prior to release — meaning he has to do less work to keep it on a straight trajectory. The bulk of his power now goes directly into sending the spear as far as possible down the centre of the field.

Long road ahead

While he may have crossed the barrier, Neeraj isn't nearly satisfied. The fact that the 90m is ultimately an

arbitrary figure was reinforced when he finished second, even after his best-ever throw.

"It is a little bit of a bittersweet result. I am very happy for the 90m, but this second place — it actually happened to me when I competed in Stockholm [Diamond League in 2022, where he threw a then national record of 89.94m]. I threw 89.94 and I was still second. And here too, I broke the national record and still finished second," he told reporters in Doha.

As he looks ahead to future competitions, he has, for now, taken at least one mandatory question out of press conferences.

"I don't know about me, but I think the burden of Indians (who were waiting for me to breach 90m) would have gone down! I think I can throw better, and I will do better. This is a long season and we have the World Championships in September. I used to throw 89m consistently, but now I will try to go over 90m regularly. *Abhi main khul ke maarunga!* (Now I'm going to throw freely)," he said.